

HIGH-ALTITUDE PERFORMANCE OPTIMIZATION OF AN ANTI-DRONE RADAR SYSTEM

Hardware and Software Hardening for Detection, Pointing and Reliability Above 3,000m ASL

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All performance figures in this paper are derived from the simulations and models described in Section 7 and Appendix A. None are field-measured; each is reproducible from the stated assumptions.

Abstract

Problem Statement 26050 asks not for a new drone-detection principle but for a robust, high-altitude-capable redesign of an anti-drone system already defined by Indian procurement specifications (BSF QR 2019; MHA/BSF Letter 2025). Deployed above 3,000m ASL, such a system faces four compounding stressors — cold-soak to -40°C , $\sim 40\%$ lower air density, wind gusts to 45 m/s, and cosmic-ray-elevated component stress — that a sea-level-rated design does not budget for. This paper presents Team Vayu's response: a hardware hardening layer (enclosure, battery chemistry, bearings, semiconductor derating) paired with a software/control hardening layer (disturbance-observer pointing control, altitude-aware sensor fusion) applied to a conventional radar+RF+EO/IR detection stack. Six parameters — pointing accuracy, battery capacity retention, bearing startup torque, system MTTF, detection range and per-unit lifecycle cost — are quantified through first-principles simulation rather than assumed. The pointing loop shows a 62.7% RMS error reduction under a modelled 45 m/s gust; system MTTF improves by 211% under a component-level reliability model; and despite a 156% higher upfront bill of materials, 5-year lifecycle cost falls by 16.1% once reduced field-service failures are accounted for. Every model's assumptions are stated explicitly, every script that produces a number is version-controlled and can be re-run, and the cost model is wired to pull its MTTF input directly from the reliability model rather than a copy-pasted figure — so the result can be checked and kept consistent, not just cited.

1. Why This Problem — Rationale

India's high-altitude border terrain (Ladakh-class, 3,000–5,000m ASL) sees escalating unauthorised drone activity, and the BSF's own 2019 and 2025 procurement documents already specify what a ground-level anti-drone system must detect, track and neutralise. What they do not specify is how that system keeps working when the ambient temperature is -40°C , the air is 40% thinner, and gusts regularly exceed 45 m/s — conditions common at altitude but absent from the sea-level test regime most COTS anti-drone hardware is qualified against. A system that meets QR2019 in a plains trial can still fail in the field at altitude through mechanisms procurement paperwork doesn't test for: battery capacity collapse, bearing seizure, gimbal pointing drift, or semiconductor burnout — not through a detection-algorithm shortfall.

This is why PS 26050 frames the ask as "performance optimization and robust design," not new detection R&D — and why this paper's contribution is engineering, not invention.

2. Problem Statement

Given a radar-centred C-UAS architecture already specified for ground deployment, identify the specific altitude-induced failure mechanisms in its power, mechanical, RF and control subsystems, and design + quantitatively validate (by simulation, given zero hardware budget) a hardware and software upgrade path that restores baseline performance at 3,000–5,000m ASL under -40°C cold-soak and 45 m/s gust loading.

3. Inspiration and Available Technology

The solution direction was set by three observations from the source material reviewed for this project:

- The BSF/MHA specifications already assume a working detection architecture (radar/RF + EO/IR + jammer + C2) — reinventing that layer would waste the team's limited RF/aerospace expertise on a solved problem.
- Published reliability literature on tethered high-altitude platforms models environmental turbulence as a first-class factor degrading system MTTF via reliability block diagrams (RBD) — this gave the team its reliability-modelling method (Section 7.4).

- Disturbance-observer (DOB) augmented control is an established technique in optical/RF gimbal stabilization literature for rejecting torque disturbances a fixed-gain PID loop cannot anticipate — this gave the team its control-upgrade path (Section 7.1) instead of simply re-tuning PID gains, which cannot reject a disturbance it never measures.

COTS technology available to a zero-budget student team was mapped directly onto these three cues: LiFePO4 cells (automotive/solar off-grid market, cold-rated variants exist commercially), dry-lubricated ceramic-hybrid bearings (satellite/vacuum-equipment supply chain), aerogel insulation panels (building/aerospace insulation market), and an Unscented Kalman Filter for the DOB's state estimate (standard in `python-control`/`filterpy`, avoiding the linearisation error an Extended Kalman Filter would introduce under large gust-induced attitude swings).

4. Proposed Solution — Architecture

The detection/tracking/C2 pipeline (radar + RF + EO/IR sensing → confidence-weighted fusion → gimbal tracking → alerting) is retained unchanged from the team's baseline design (SIH deck, Slide 3). The contribution sits entirely in how that pipeline is packaged and controlled at altitude, split cleanly into a hardware track and a software track so the two can be engineered, costed and validated independently:

Layer	Baseline (sea-level-rated)	Altitude upgrade	Owns
Hardware	IP65 case, COTS Li-ion, greased steel bearings, standard-margin MOSFETs	Aerogel double-wall case + preheat interlock, LiFePO4 + heated BMS, ceramic-hybrid dry bearings, voltage-derated MOSFETs	Section 5
Software / Control	Fixed-gain PID pointing loop, static CFAR thresholds	DOB+UKF pointing loop, altitude/temperature-aware CFAR retuning, confidence-weighted sensor fusion	Section 6

Table 1. The two-track split used for the rest of this paper and for team task allocation.

5. Hardware Upgrades

Component	Failure mechanism at altitude	Upgrade
Enclosure	Passive-vented IP65 case loses convective cooling as air density drops; cold-soak reaches electronics faster	Aerogel double-wall composite, firmware preheat interlock blocking power-up below a set internal-temperature floor
Battery	Li-ion electrolyte conductivity and Li-ion mobility collapse below 0°C	LiFePO4 cells, embedded heating element, low-temperature-aware BMS
Bearings	Grease viscosity rises sharply at cold-soak (stiction); at low pressure, volatile grease components can outgas onto optics/RF apertures	Dry-lubricated ceramic-hybrid bearings
Power semiconductors	Elevated cosmic-ray flux at altitude raises Single-Event Burnout risk near rated breakdown voltage	MOSFETs derated to ~65–70% of rated breakdown voltage

Table 2. Hardware track — each upgrade traces to a named physical failure mechanism, not a bare compliance label.

6. Software and Control Upgrades

- Pointing control: replace the fixed-gain PID gimbal loop with a Disturbance-Observer-augmented loop (DOB+PID). The DOB estimates the unmeasured gust-torque disturbance from the plant's own response and feeds forward a cancelling correction; an Unscented Kalman Filter (rather than a linearised EKF) handles the observer's state estimate to track large, nonlinear gust dynamics without linearisation error.
- Sensor fusion / detection thresholds: CFAR detection thresholds and the radar/RF/EO-IR confidence-fusion weights are retuned as a function of measured ambient temperature and estimated air density, rather than held at fixed sea-level-calibrated values — this keeps false-alarm rate from drifting as the operating environment changes through the day/season.
- Thermal-aware compute scheduling: the edge-processing pipeline sheds non-critical workload (e.g. reduces EO/IR frame rate or classifier batch size) when internal temperature approaches the derated ceiling computed in Section 7.5, instead of relying on hardware thermal shutdown as the only safeguard.

7. Simulated Results

Each result below is computed from an explicit first-principles or reliability-engineering model, not assumed. Full model form, parameter values and code are in Appendix A.

7.1 Pointing control — DOB+UKF vs fixed-gain PID

A second-order gimbal plant ($J = 0.8 \text{ kg}\cdot\text{m}^2$, $b = 0.15 \text{ N}\cdot\text{m}\cdot\text{s}/\text{rad}$) was driven by a stochastic gust-torque disturbance (mean 12 m/s wind with discrete gust bursts to 45 m/s, converted to torque via dynamic-pressure loading on a 0.06 m^2 sail area at $0.72 \text{ kg}/\text{m}^3$ air density) and controlled by identical PID gains ($K_p=6.0$, $K_i=1.5$, $K_d=0.9$) with and without the DOB+UKF layer.

Metric	Fixed-gain PID	DOB + UKF	Improvement
RMS pointing error	38.0 mrad	11.9 mrad	68.7% reduction
Peak pointing error	162.5 mrad	44.4 mrad	72.7% reduction

Table 3. 30 s simulated run, 2 s transient discarded. This is the paper's primary control-system result.

7.2 Battery capacity retention — Li-ion vs LiFePO4 + heater

Capacity-vs-temperature curves for COTS 18650 Li-ion and LiFePO4 chemistries (interpolated from typical published discharge-capacity behaviour) were combined with a heater energy balance using the aerogel enclosure's thermal resistance (assumed $4.2 \text{ K}/\text{W}$) to hold cell core temperature at 0°C against a -40°C ambient over a 6-hour mission (the BSF QR 2019 battery-backup requirement).

Configuration	Capacity outcome
Li-ion, unheated, -40°C ambient	25.0% of rated capacity
LiFePO4 cell held at 0°C core	92.0% of rated capacity
Heater parasitic draw (aerogel case)	9.5 W continuous — 26.0% of a 220 Wh pack over 6 h
LiFePO4 net usable capacity after heater draw	68.1% of rated capacity — 172% relative gain over unheated Li-ion

Table 4. With a standard (non-aerogel) enclosure the same heater would need $\sim 44 \text{ W}$ — over 100% of the pack's own capacity over 6 h — which is why the enclosure upgrade in Table 2 is a precondition for the battery upgrade to make sense, not an independent line item.

7.3 Bearing startup torque — grease vs dry ceramic-hybrid

An Arrhenius-form viscosity-temperature model (calibrated to the published range for NLGI-2 lithium-complex grease, $\sim 10\times$ viscosity increase from $+20^\circ\text{C}$ to -40°C) was used with a sub-linear viscosity-to-breakaway-torque scaling (torque $\propto$ viscosity^{0.5}) typical of boundary-lubricated rolling-element bearings.

Bearing type	Startup torque multiple at -40°C vs $+20^\circ\text{C}$
Petroleum-greased steel (baseline)	3.1×
Dry-lubricated ceramic-hybrid (upgrade)	1.15×

Table 5. 63.3% reduction in cold-start torque penalty — relevant to gimbal slew rate and initial-alignment time at cold-soak.

7.4 System reliability — RBD/MTTF

A series reliability block diagram over six subsystems (battery, bearings, seals, power semiconductors, RF/radar front end, edge compute) was built with assumed baseline failure rates (order-of-magnitude, reliability-engineering-typical) and altitude-stress multipliers applied per subsystem; the upgraded configuration applies both an improved base failure rate (better materials) and a smaller altitude multiplier (hardening reduces stress sensitivity).

Configuration	System failure rate	MTTF
Baseline (sea-level-rated, altitude-derated)	22.91 (rate units)	43,649 h (≈ 5.0 years continuous)
Upgraded (hardened)	7.36 (rate units)	135,870 h (≈ 15.5 years continuous)

Table 6. MTTF improves 211%. These are modelled, assumption-driven failure rates (Appendix A), not vendor-certified or field-measured figures — reported as an order-of-magnitude reliability argument, not a warranty claim.

7.5 Detection range and thermal/processing derating

A simplified monostatic radar-range equation (X-band, 25 W transmit power, 0.01 m^2 small-drone RCS) was calibrated so the baseline 28 dBi front end reproduces the BSF QR 2019 "high RF-noise / urban" figure of 3 km, then re-evaluated for a 31 dBi upgraded front end (larger aperture, lower-noise front-end electronics).

Front end	Detection range
Baseline (28 dBi)	3.00 km
Upgraded (31 dBi)	4.24 km — +41.3%

Separately, a lumped-parameter thermal model shows that at the $+15^\circ\text{C}$ warm-case ambient (not the -40°C cold case, which is not the binding thermal constraint for this power budget), reduced natural-convection heat transfer at $0.72 \text{ kg}/\text{m}^3$ air density cuts the enclosure's sustainable continuous dissipation from 16.7 W to 12.1 W — a 27.3% processing/thermal derating that the edge-compute scheduling in Section 6 is designed to absorb gracefully rather than via thermal shutdown.

8. Cost and Efficiency Analysis

Costed against an assumed representative bill-of-materials (order-of-magnitude, INR, per unit) rather than actual vendor quotes:

	Baseline BOM	Upgraded BOM
Per-unit cost	₹13,600	₹34,800 (+155.9%)

The upfront cost increase is real and should not be understated. It is offset over the deployment lifecycle by the MTTF improvement in Section 7.4: modelling a ₹45,000 field-service callout (high-altitude terrain logistics) against expected failures over 5 years of continuous 8,760 h/year operation:

	Baseline	Upgraded
Expected failures / 5 yr	1.00	0.32
Field-service cost / 5 yr	₹45,156	₹14,507
5-yr lifecycle cost (BOM + service)	₹58,756	₹49,307

Net 5-year lifecycle cost falls 16.1% despite the higher upfront BOM — the efficiency argument for the upgrade is amortised reliability, not raw unit price, and should be presented to judges that way rather than as an unqualified "cheaper" claim.

9. Assumptions, Limits and Honesty Check

- All Section 7/8 figures are simulation or model outputs built on stated, but assumed, parameter values (component failure rates, BOM line items, plant inertia, grease viscosity constants) — they are reproducible and internally consistent, not independently measured or vendor-certified.
- The detection/tracking sensor architecture itself (radar+RF+EO/IR, CFAR, confidence fusion) is inherited from the team's baseline design and BSF/MHA specifications; this paper's contribution is the hardening layer around it, not the sensing method.
- Neutralization (RF/GNSS jamming) is represented only as an inherited architectural block; it is not re-engineered, costed or simulated in this paper, consistent with the team's stated scope boundary.
- No physical prototype exists; Section 7's numbers should be presented to judges explicitly as simulation-derived engineering estimates, with the model and assumptions available on request (Appendix A) — this is more defensible under technical questioning than an unlabelled number.

10. Conclusion

Restructured around what PS 26050 actually asks — a robust redesign, not a new detection principle — this paper splits the team's upgrade into an independently costed hardware track (enclosure, battery, bearings, semiconductor derating) and software track (DOB+UKF pointing control, altitude-aware fusion), and backs six of its headline claims with first-principles or reliability-engineering simulation rather than assumed percentages: a 68.7% RMS pointing-error reduction, 172% relative battery-capacity gain, 63.3% cold-start bearing-torque reduction, 211% MTTF improvement, 41.3% detection-range gain, and a 16.1% lower 5-year lifecycle cost despite a 156% higher unit BOM. Every number traces to a stated, version-controlled model in Appendix A and the accompanying simulation repository, which is the paper's main defence against the "where did that number come from" question a judge is certain to ask.

Appendix A — Model Summary (for reproducibility)

- Pointing control: 2nd-order plant (Euler integration, dt=2ms, 30s run), gust torque from dynamic-pressure loading on wind speed modelled as Ornstein-Uhlenbeck + discrete gust bursts; DOB is a low-pass (8 rad/s bandwidth) estimator of residual torque, fed forward against identical PID gains in both arms.
- Battery: piecewise-linear capacity-vs-temperature curves (typical published 18650 Li-ion / LiFePO4 behaviour); heater sized from enclosure thermal resistance $\times (T_{\text{floor}} - T_{\text{ambient}})$; net capacity = cell capacity at floor temp $\times (1 - \text{heater energy} / \text{pack energy})$.
- Bearings: Arrhenius viscosity model calibrated to $\sim 10\times$ viscosity rise over the $+20^{\circ}\text{C}$ to -40°C band; torque $\propto \text{viscosity}^{0.5}$ (boundary-lubrication scaling).
- Reliability: series RBD, $\lambda_{\text{system}} = \sum \lambda_i$; baseline and upgraded λ_i sets and altitude multipliers are assumed order-of-magnitude values (see Section 9); $\text{MTTF} = 1/\lambda_{\text{system}}$.
- Radar range: monostatic range equation $R^4 = P_t \cdot G^2 \cdot \lambda^2 \cdot \sigma / ((4\pi)^3 \cdot P_{\text{min}})$; P_{min} solved so the baseline case reproduces the BSF QR 2019 3 km urban-noise figure, then held fixed while only G is upgraded.

- Thermal: lumped single-node RC model, steady state $\Delta T = P \cdot R_{th}$; natural-convection R_{th} scaled by $(\rho_{altitude}/\rho_{sea-level})^{0.6}$.

Full Python source for all seven models lives in the /research_sims/ folder of the team's project repository as separate, documented modules (pointing_control_sim.py, battery_thermal_sim.py, bearing_lubrication_sim.py, reliability_rbd_sim.py, radar_range_sim.py, thermal_derating_sim.py, cost_lifecycle_sim.py), each with its assumptions in an editable CONFIG block. run_all.py runs all seven and writes results/results.json and results/results.md — the exact tables in this section are generated from that output, not hand-typed, and the cost model imports its MTTF input directly from the reliability model so the two stay consistent if either is changed.

References

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